Precious Metals Rally into the Weekend Close

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Abstract

Gold and silver futures rise in the last hour before CME closes for the weekend. A long position from 16:00 to 16:59 New York time on Fridays earned +3.6 bp in gold (GC, $t = 8.4$, 60% of Fridays positive, 16 of 17 years) and +6.8 bp in silver (SI, $t = 8.9$, 17 of 17 years) over 795 Fridays from 2010 to 2026. The same hour on Monday to Thursday, which ends at the same daily 17:00 break, shows nothing in gold (+0.2 bp, $t = 1.1$).

The size of the move follows the length of the closure ahead: zero before the one-hour daily break, +3.7 bp in gold and +6.6 bp in silver before a normal weekend, and +6.6 bp and +16.4 bp before a long weekend such as Easter. It is larger after a falling week and in volatile weeks, and it is not reversed when the market reopens. This points to traders flattening short exposure before they lose the ability to trade, rather than to temporary price pressure.

On a retail gold CFD, with a 24-minute window that closes before the broker stops quoting, the trade earned +8.5 R over 63 Fridays from June 2025 to October 2026 after a $0.19 spread and commission (profit factor 1.76, 62% winners), but with $t = 1.6$ the live-cost evidence is still weak. Here 1 R is the loss at the stop.

AI disclosure. The author used Claude (Anthropic), an AI assistant, to write the data-analysis code, to draft and edit the text, to assist with wording and structure, and as a consultative tool for discussing methodological and technical questions. The research questions and the decisions on what to test and what to accept are the author's. The author reviewed, verified, and edited all AI-assisted content and takes full responsibility for the content of the paper, including its analysis, results, and conclusions.

1 Hypothesis and mechanism

The hypothesis is that traders who hold short or hedged positions in precious metals reduce them before a market closure, because they cannot react to news while the market is shut, and that this buying lifts the price in the final minutes before the close.

CME metals futures trade almost around the clock. From Monday to Thursday the session pauses for one hour at 17:00 New York time; on Friday the 17:00 close starts a 49-hour weekend. Gold and silver are the assets that investors buy on bad news, so the risk of a weekend headline is asymmetric for anyone short: geopolitical or financial shocks tend to gap them higher. A trader who is short, or who sold futures against physical holdings, has a reason to cover before the close; a long has much less reason to sell. If that motive is large enough to be net buying, the price should rise into Friday's close.

The study cannot see who trades, so the mechanism is inferred. It makes four testable predictions:

1. The rise is concentrated before closures and absent before the ordinary one-hour daily break.
2. It grows with the length of the closure ahead: larger before a long weekend than before a normal one.

3. It is larger when there is more short exposure to cover, after a falling week, and when weekend risk feels higher, in volatile weeks.

4. It is not reversed at the reopen, because it reflects a change in positions rather than temporary liquidity pressure.

All four are supported by the data (Sections 4 and 5), although the evidence for the second rests on long weekends: closures before weekday holidays are too few to tell.

Calendar effects around weekends have a long history, starting with the negative Monday returns in US equities documented by French (1980), and Heston et al. (2010) show that intraday returns recur at the same time of day. The effect studied here is narrower: it sits in a single hour, in precious metals only, and follows the schedule of the exchange rather than the day of the week.

2 Data

The study uses futures for the long history and the broker's own prices for the tradable result.

Exhibit 1. Data sets

Data set	Period	Resolution	Use
CME gold (GC), silver (SI) and platinum (PL) futures, front contract, Databento	June 2010 – September 2026	1 minute	effect, its history and mechanism tests
Twelve other CME futures: palladium, copper, crude oil, equity indices, Treasuries and currencies	2010 – 2026	1 minute	is it specific to precious metals?
Retail XAUUSD CFD (MetaTrader 5 broker)	June 2025 – October 2026	1-minute bars and real ticks with bid and ask	strategy backtest, spreads near the close

All times are New York time, because the CME schedule follows it, including its daylight-saving dates. In London time the Friday close is usually at 22:00, but at 21:00 for about three weeks a year when US and UK clock changes are out of step. Until June 2015 the metals session closed at 17:15 rather than 17:00, with a 45-minute pause.

Market closures are taken from the data: a closure is a gap of at least 45 minutes between one-minute bars after which trading resumes at the scheduled reopening, 18:00. This excludes data outages, which resume at random times. The length of a closure is measured until the next bar.

3 Method

The main trade is a long from the close of the 15:59 bar (16:00) to the close of the last bar at or before 16:58 (16:59) on Fridays. The placebo is the same hour on Monday to Thursday, which ends at the same 17:00 daily break but has only a one-hour pause ahead. Returns are in basis points of the entry price so that 2011 and 2026 are comparable; Fridays when the exchange closes early, before 16:30, are left out of the main sample.

The closure test uses every pause in trading, not just Fridays. For each one the return over the 60 minutes before the last bar is grouped by the length of the pause ahead: one hour (the daily

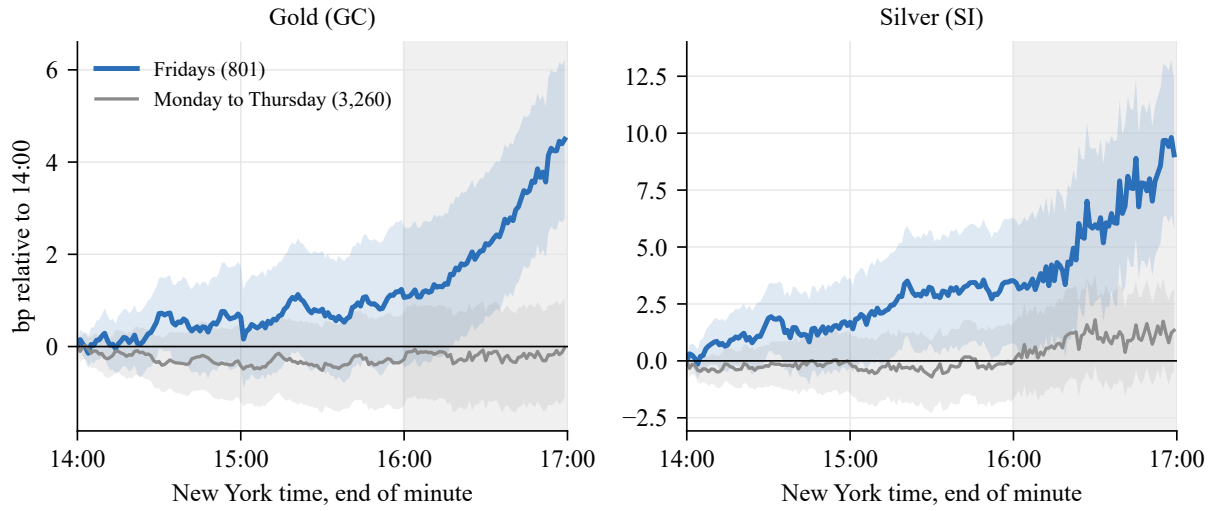
break), 12 to 40 hours (a weekday holiday), 40 to 55 hours (a normal weekend) and over 55 hours (a long weekend).

The main statistic is the t-statistic of the mean, and each result is also checked year by year. Because many patterns have been tested on the same 16 years, a t-statistic below about 3 is treated as inconclusive, following the multiple-testing threshold of Harvey et al. (2016). Sharpe ratios are annualised from one trade a week by multiplying by $\sqrt{52}$.

4 Results

From June 2010 to September 2026 the Friday hour returned +3.62 bp in gold ($t = 8.4$, 60% positive) and +6.78 bp in silver ($t = 8.9$, 62% positive) before costs. On Monday to Thursday the same hour returned +0.22 bp in gold ($t = 1.1$) and +1.20 bp in silver ($t = 3.4$); the difference between Fridays and other days has $t = 7.1$ in gold and 6.7 in silver. The result does not come from rolling between contracts: using a single contract each day, the one most traded that afternoon, gives +3.71 bp in gold ($t = 8.6$), and trimming the most extreme 1% of Fridays at each end gives +3.59 bp. The median Friday gains 2.4 bp.

Exhibit 2. Average futures price on Fridays and on other weekdays, 14:00 to 17:00 New York time, basis points relative to 14:00

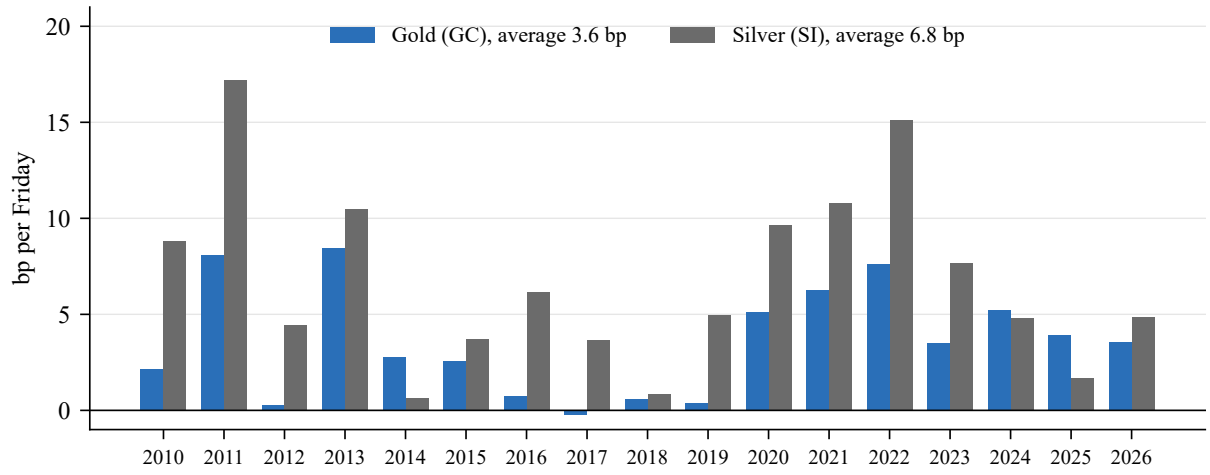


Notes:
– Average close at the end of each minute relative to the close of the 13:59 bar; number of days in brackets.
– Bands: 95% confidence intervals for the mean.
– Shaded area: the trading window, 16:00 to 17:00.
Source: CME GC and SI futures, front contract, Databento 1-minute bars, June 2010 – September 2026.

On Fridays gold drifts up slowly through the afternoon (+1.1 bp by 16:00, $t = 1.4$) and then accelerates: +2.2 bp by 16:30, +3.3 bp by 16:45 and +4.5 bp by 16:59. Three quarters of the afternoon move comes in the final hour, and a quarter of that hour's move in its last ten minutes (42% in silver). On other weekdays the line stays flat into the 17:00 break.

Before July 2015, when the session closed at 17:15, the rise continued to the actual close: in gold the quarter hour from 17:00 to 17:15 added +1.3 bp on Fridays ($t = 2.8$) and −0.3 bp on other weekdays. The move follows the close, not the clock.

Exhibit 3. Long from 16:00 to 16:59 New York time on Fridays, by year, basis points per Friday before costs



Notes:
– 2010 starts in June and 2026 ends in September.
Source: CME GC and SI futures, front contract, Databento 1-minute bars.

Silver is positive in all 17 calendar years and gold in 16; the exception is 2017 at −0.3 bp. The weak period is the quiet years 2012 and 2016–2019 for gold; the strongest years are 2011, 2013 and 2021–2022. Annualised from one trade a week, the Sharpe ratio before costs is 2.2 for gold and 2.3 for silver, with a yearly range of −0.3 to 5.8 for gold. In 2025 and 2026 the effect is still positive in basis points (+3.9 and +3.6 in gold) but noisier ($t = 1.8$ and 0.8), because gold's volatility has risen while the move has not.

At a gold price of $4,000, 3.6 bp is about $1.45 per ounce, against a gold CFD spread of about $0.19 near the Friday close (Section 6).

Exhibit 4. The same hour across CME futures: Fridays against Monday to Thursday

Market	Group	Fri, bp	t	Mon–Thu, bp	t	t, diff.	Years +
Gold (GC)	precious	+3.62	+8.4	+0.22	+1.1	+7.1	16/17
Silver (SI)	precious	+6.78	+8.9	+1.20	+3.4	+6.7	17/17
Platinum (PL)	precious	+2.74	+4.0	−0.02	−0.1	+3.7	13/17
Palladium (PA)	industrial	+1.04	+0.9	+0.39	+0.8	+0.5	13/17
Copper (HG)	industrial	+0.97	+1.9	+0.37	+1.6	+1.1	13/17
WTI crude (CL)	energy	+2.04	+2.6	+0.62	+1.1	+1.5	12/17
Brent crude (BZ)	energy	+2.28	+2.2	+0.85	+1.2	+1.2	8/16
S&P 500 (ES)	equity	−0.41	−0.6	+0.93	+2.4	−1.7	4/12
Nasdaq 100 (NQ)	equity	−0.48	−0.7	+2.03	+3.7	−2.8	5/12
10-year Treasury (ZN)	rates	+0.03	+0.2	−0.43	−4.7	+2.4	11/17
30-year Treasury (ZB)	rates	+0.51	+1.5	−0.38	−2.1	+2.3	11/17
Euro (6E)	currency	+0.63	+2.6	+0.25	+2.6	+1.5	11/17
Yen (6J)	currency	−0.64	−1.8	−0.74	−5.6	+0.3	4/17
Pound (6B)	currency	−0.04	−0.2	+0.33	+3.2	−1.3	8/17
Australian dollar (6A)	currency	−0.33	−1.1	+0.40	+2.9	−2.1	6/17

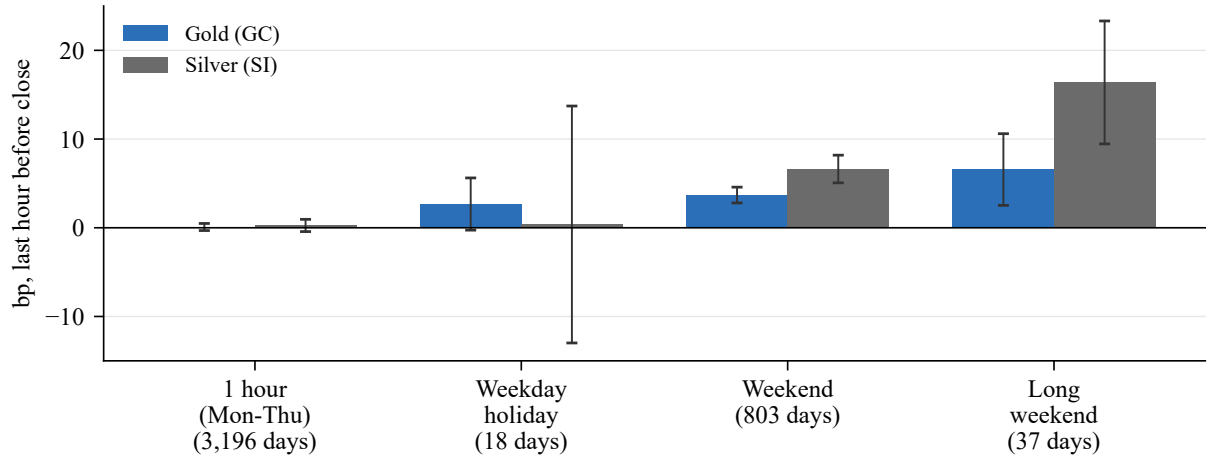
Notes:
– Long from 16:00 to 16:59 New York time, basis points per day before costs.
– "t, diff.": t-statistic of the difference between Fridays and other days.
– "Years +": calendar years with a positive Friday average.
– Equity index rows start in late 2015: before then the data have no trading between 16:15 and 17:00.
Source: CME futures, front contract, Databento 1-minute bars, 2010–2026.

The effect belongs to precious metals: gold, silver and platinum clear $t = 3$ on Fridays and against the other weekdays; palladium, which behaves as an industrial metal, does not, and neither do copper or oil. The signs elsewhere fit the same story without being conclusive on their own: equity index futures fall slightly into the Friday close relative to other days (Nasdaq $t = -2.8$ for the difference) and Treasuries lose their usual weekday decline, as if risk is being reduced across the board before the weekend.

5 What drives the move

The cleanest test of the mechanism uses every closure in the 16 years and asks whether the final hour depends on how long the market will be shut.

Exhibit 5. Return over the last hour before a market closure, by the length of the closure ahead, basis points



Notes:

- Every scheduled closure, June 2010 – September 2026: a pause of at least 45 minutes after which trading resumes at 18:00.
- One hour: the daily break, Monday to Thursday. Weekday holiday: a pause of 12 to 40 hours, mostly Christmas Eve and New Year's Eve. Weekend: 40 to 55 hours. Long weekend: over 55 hours, mostly Easter and Christmas or New Year next to a weekend, plus US Monday holidays in 2013–2014.
- Error bars: 95% confidence intervals.

Source: CME GC and SI futures, front contract, Databento 1-minute bars.

In gold the final hour returns nothing before the daily break (+0.08 bp, $t = 0.4$, 3,196 days), +3.7 bp before a weekend ($t = 8.1$, 803 days) and +6.6 bp before a long weekend ($t = 3.2$, 37 days, 76% positive). Silver shows the same order, from +0.3 bp to +6.6 bp and +16.4 bp ($t = 4.6$). Weekday holidays are too few to separate: 18 closures, +2.7 bp in gold ($t = 1.8$) and +0.4 bp in silver. Holiday sessions that halt early but reopen the same evening show no rise (−0.9 bp, 88 days).

The long-weekend group is small, but it was not chosen by looking at returns: it is defined by the exchange calendar, and its result, larger than a normal weekend in both metals, is what the mechanism predicts and what a pure day-of-week pattern does not.

Exhibit 6. The Friday hour by conditions known at entry, and what happens after the close

		Gold (GC)		Silver (SI)	
Condition	Fridays	bp	t	bp	t
Week up to Friday 16:00 rose	431	+2.25	+4.3	+5.96	+6.3
Week up to Friday 16:00 fell	364	+5.24	+7.5	+7.62	+6.3
Quietest third of weeks	271	+2.02	+3.8	+2.42	+2.5
Middle third	256	+2.27	+3.4	+5.48	+5.0
Most volatile third	268	+6.54	+6.9	+12.41	+7.4
After the Friday close, from 16:59:					
to Sunday 19:00 (first hour after reopen)	781	+2.77	+1.9	+8.05	+2.9
to Monday 09:30	792	−0.98	−0.4	+3.78	+0.8
to Monday 16:00	727	−1.90	−0.5	+0.04	+0.0
Benchmark: Mon–Thu, 16:59 to 19:00	2,900	+1.29	+4.1	+1.99	+3.1

Notes:
– Upper rows: long from 16:00 to 16:59 New York time on Fridays, basis points before costs; "Fridays" gives the gold count.
– Week: from Monday 16:00 to Friday 16:00. Volatility: average sum of absolute one-minute moves, 08:00–16:00, Monday to Thursday; thirds formed within each year so that the long-run rise in volatility does not drive the split.
– Lower rows: return from the Friday close to later points; positive values mean no reversal.
Source: CME GC and SI futures, front contract, Databento 1-minute bars, 2010–2026.

Three findings support the covering story:

- **More to cover, more buying.** In gold the Friday hour is more than twice as large after a falling week (+5.2 bp) as after a rising one (+2.3 bp), when more traders are likely to be short. Silver leans the same way, less strongly. The Friday session alone does not matter: the correlation between the move from 09:30 to 16:00 and the final hour is −0.08 in gold and +0.04 in silver.
- **More weekend risk, more buying.** The move is three times larger in gold, and five times in silver, in the most volatile third of weeks than in the quietest. Measured in units of the day's own hourly volatility instead of basis points, it is the same size in gold and silver, about 12% of one hour's standard deviation ($t = 8.3$ and 9.4).
- **No reversal.** If the rise were temporary pressure from a one-sided rush to trade, prices should fall back when the market reopens. They do not: from the Friday close to the first hour on Sunday evening gold gains another 2.8 bp and silver 8.1 bp, at or above the ordinary overnight drift, and by Monday afternoon the change is indistinguishable from zero. The price paid by shorts to exit is kept.

Two obvious alternatives fit the data less well. A general safe-haven bid would be expected in the yen too, and the yen shows nothing. Settlement flows do not fit the timing: gold and silver futures settle at about 13:30, and the move is concentrated after 16:00, when US equity markets and gold ETFs have already closed.

6 Trading it on a retail CFD

The broker's gold CFD closes for the weekend shortly before the futures: the last Friday tick arrives at a median 16:56 New York time, and the spread widens into the close, from $0.10 at 16:00 to

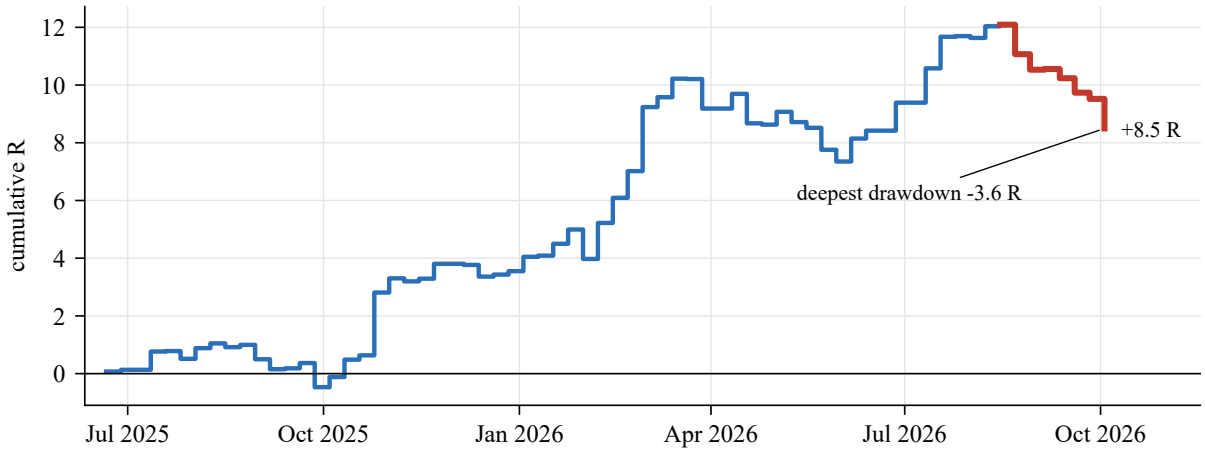
a median \$0.17 at 16:50 (90th percentile \$0.57) and \$0.19 at 16:55 (90th percentile \$1.04). The tradable window therefore starts at 16:30 and exits by time at 16:54, which on GC futures earns +2.1 bp ($t = 8.0$, 15 of 17 years), about 60% of the full hour. A stop at 0.15% of the price (about \$6.50) caps the loss of a single Friday.

Exhibit 7. Strategy results on the CFD, long from 16:30 to 16:54 New York time on Fridays, June 2025 – October 2026

Spread	Trades	Total, R	R per trade	Win rate	PF	t	Max DD, R
\$0.19 (median at 16:55)	63	+8.5	+0.135	62%	1.76	1.6	3.6
\$0.30 (stress)	63	+7.3	+0.117	60%	1.66	1.4	–

Notes:
– Event-driven backtest on the broker's 1-minute bars with stops resolved on ticks; \$6 commission per lot.
– 1 R is the loss at the stop, about \$77 per trade here, or 0.10–0.15 lots.
– 58 trades exited by time and 5 at the stop.
– PF: profit factor, gross profit divided by gross loss. Max DD: deepest fall from a peak, in R.
Source: author's backtest on MetaTrader 5 broker data for XAUUSD.

Exhibit 8. Cumulative net result of the CFD strategy, in R



Notes:
– One trade per Friday after spread (\$0.19) and commission, in R, summed over time.
– Red segment: the deepest peak-to-trough drawdown, still open at the end of the sample.
Source: author's backtest on MetaTrader 5 broker data for XAUUSD.

The average trade moved \$1.18 per ounce in the right direction from mid-price to mid-price (median \$0.62), against about \$0.25 of spread and commission. The result is positive but not yet convincing: 63 trades give $t = 1.6$, only 8 of 17 months were positive, and the last seven Fridays in the sample lost 3.6 R. The CFD sample covers an unusually volatile gold market, in which, as Exhibit 3 shows, the futures effect was also at its noisiest. Annualised, the Sharpe ratio after costs is 1.5.

7 Limitations and risks

- **Weak tradable evidence.** The effect is strong in 16 years of futures but only 1.6 standard errors from zero on the instrument that would actually be traded. The strategy has run on a demo account only since the start of October 2026, too briefly to compare with the backtest.
- **The last minutes are the expensive ones.** A quarter of the gold move and 42% of the silver move come in the last ten minutes, when the CFD spread is widest and the broker is about to stop quoting. The CFD captures only part of the effect.
- **Weekend exposure by accident.** An exit order that fails before the broker's close turns a 24-minute trade into a 49-hour one. Fridays with an early close (after Thanksgiving, around Christmas) need the schedule to be checked, and the strategy skips a Friday when the 16:29 bar is missing.
- **Multiple testing.** The Friday hour was found in a scan of day-of-week and time-of-day windows across several markets. Its t-statistics of 8 to 9, the placebo on other weekdays and the closure-length ordering make chance an unlikely explanation, but the smaller holiday groups (17 to 37 closures) should be read as consistent with the mechanism rather than as proof.
- **Unobserved mechanism.** Covering of shorts is inferred from the pattern, not from position data. Commitments of Traders reports, which show weekly positioning by trader type, could test it directly.

8 Conclusion

Gold, silver and platinum futures rise into the Friday close, and the rise is tied to the closure itself: it is absent before the ordinary daily break, appears before weekends, is largest before long weekends, and before July 2015 ran on to the old 17:15 close. It is larger after falling weeks and in volatile weeks and is not reversed at the reopen, which fits traders paying to close short exposure they do not want to carry through a period when they cannot trade. Silver is positive in every calendar year since 2010 and gold in all but one.

The effect is large relative to futures costs, but much of it comes in the final minutes, where a retail CFD is most expensive and least available. On the CFD the trade is positive after costs but not yet statistically convincing.

Next steps:

- Keep the demo account running for several months to measure fills and spreads in the final minutes directly.
- Test whether CFTC positioning (net shorts of money managers) predicts the size of the Friday move.
- Check silver on the CFD, where the futures effect is twice as large in basis points.

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